1.3 Eastern American Cultures

You climb to the top of the tower at Serpent Mound in southern Ohio and look down at the amazing sight below. It really does appear to be a gigantic, grass-covered snake slithering across the landscape with an egg or a jewel in its mouth. How did it get here? Who made it, and when?

MAIN IDEA Native Americans in eastern North America established stable agricultural societies and specialized burial and religious practices.



Ancient Mounds
Serpent Mound in Adams County, Ohio, resembles a writhing snake. The mound stretches more than 1,300 feet. It is estimated to be between 1,000 and 2,000 years old.

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THE MOUND BUILDERS

Serpent Mound and other mounds like it began dotting the North American landscape around 1000 B.C. The people who created these structures are known as the **Mound Builders**. They lived in the river valleys of the Midwest and eastern United States. These earthen mounds came in different shapes and sizes and served a variety of purposes. Some housed the dead, and others served as temples.

The Adena and Hopewell were two cultures that built mounds. Both groups lived chiefly in the southern part of present-day Ohio, where Serpent Mound is located. They also settled in the region we now call Indiana, Kentucky, West Virginia, Michigan, Wisconsin, and Pennsylvania. Both groups were primarily hunter-gatherers, though the Hopewell farmed as well. Studies of the Hopewell Mound Group have determined that their mounds served as ancient burial sites.

A couple of hundred years after the Hopewell culture died out, the Mississippians emerged. Beginning in about A.D. 700, this group spread across North America from present-day Georgia to Minnesota. The Mississippians topped their mounds with grand temples or chiefs' residences. Cahokia (kuh-HO-kee-yuh), a grouping of mounds located in Illinois, served as the culture's capital. At the Cahokia Mounds site, Monks Mound stands nearly 100 feet high. Its base is larger than that of the Great Pyramid of Giza in Egypt.

Unlike the hunter-gatherer cultures of the Adena and Hopewell, the Mississippians were largely agricultural. For food, they planted crops such as corn, beans, and squash. Having a large and dependable harvest helped them feed a large population. Cahokia alone may have housed as many as 15,000 people.

PEOPLE OF THE WOODLANDS

Just as the Mississippians depended on farming for their livelihoods, so too did the tribes who lived after them in the woodlands of eastern and southeastern North America.

The mild climate of the Southeast made it an ideal place to grow crops. The Chickasaw and Choctaw of present-day Mississippi and Alabama grew corn, beans, and pumpkins. Women planted and harvested the crops. They also cooked, cared for the children, and made baskets, clothes, and other goods. Men cleared the land, constructed buildings, hunted, served as warriors, and engaged in trade. Both the Chickasaw and Choctaw societies were **matrilineal**, meaning they traced their family lines through their mothers.

Agriculture was so important to these groups that one of their religious ceremonies was a Green Corn festival. The festival was held each summer as the corn began to ripen. Over a series of days, people fasted, feasted, danced, played games, and prayed.

The region in which the Eastern Woodlands people lived was heavily wooded, which explains its name. The tribes of the Eastern Woodlands practiced a technique known as **slash-and-burn agriculture**. This method involved cutting down and burning trees to clear land, and it supported the groups' pattern of moving frequently. Their farms were not permanent.

Two groups, named for the languages they spoke, lived in the Eastern Woodlands: the Algonquian (al-GAHN-kwee-uhn) and the Iroquois (IHR-uh-kwoy). The Algonquian lived along the Atlantic coast. The Iroquois primarily lived in the central part of present-day New York State. In Algonquian groups, men were the heads of households, but Iroquois society was matrilineal, and women shared political power with men. Five Iroquois-speaking nations banded together to form the **Iroquois League**: the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga (kah-YOO-guh), and Seneca. This brought long-lasting peace among them. The Iroquois nations still exist to this day.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did farming help maintain a large population in Cahokia?
2. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** How did the Eastern Woodlands people solve the problem of growing food in forests?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why would the mild climate of the Southeast have made it an ideal place to grow crops?

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